The First Count

One day of tally marks to find out what your household throws away most. Free, and the first step of The Waste Audit Workbook.

Free edition, November 2026

Measured, not promised.

Read This First

Most people begin a low-waste routine by buying something. A set of bags, a bamboo brush, a jar. Then the item sits in a drawer, because it did not match anything they actually throw away.

This guide does the opposite. You count first. You buy later, and only if the count says to.

The method takes one day and a pen. Each time something goes into the trash, the recycling or the compost, you make one mark on the sheet. You do not sort through garbage. You do not weigh anything. A mark takes about five seconds.

At the end of the day you have a short table of numbers that belong to your household. They will not match anyone else's. A person who works from home and drinks four cups of tea has a different pattern from a family that orders dinner. A list of "top ten swaps" cannot see that. Your tally can.

What one day can tell you

One day shows you which kinds of items repeat. That is enough to pick one thing to try this week.

What one day cannot tell you

One day is a small sample. It misses the weekly shop, the takeout night and anything you buy once a month. Do not turn one day into a yearly number, and do not buy anything large because of it.

This guide also does not tell you how much your waste weighs or how much carbon a change saves. Those figures depend on materials, on your local recycling and on how far a product travels. A home tally cannot measure them honestly, so this one does not try.

What you need

- This sheet, printed, or open on a tablet.
- A pen kept where the trash is. Tape it to the lid if you have to.
- One day that looks roughly normal.

How to Count

Mark at the moment you throw it away

The whole method depends on one habit. When you throw something away, make a mark before you walk away from the bin.

Do not plan to fill the sheet in at night. By evening you will remember the dramatic items, such as the takeout container, and forget the small repeating ones, such as the tea bag, the produce bag and the paper towel. The small repeating items are usually the ones worth changing.

Count items, not sizes

One mark is one item. A yogurt tub is one mark. A bread bag is one mark. A paper towel sheet is one mark, even though it is small, because the repeat count is what you are after.

Count every bin

Mark what goes to the trash, the recycling and the compost. A recyclable item is still a single-use item. Whether it really gets recycled depends on your local program and on whether it was clean and sorted. Counting it tells you how much you use, and that is the number a change can reduce.

Count for the whole household if you can

If you share the home, ask the others to make marks. If they will not, count what you can see and write "only me" at the top of the sheet. A partial count is still useful.

What the categories mean

- **Food packaging:** bags, wrappers, tubs, lids, pouches, cartons, bottles and cans from groceries.
- **Produce bags:** the thin bags used for fruit, vegetables and bulk goods.
- **Paper towels and wipes:** paper towels, napkins, disposable wipes, tissues used in the kitchen or for cleaning.
- **Coffee and tea:** filters, pods, tea bags, cups, lids, stirrers.
- **Bathroom:** empties and disposables such as bottles, tubes, floss, cotton rounds, razor heads.
- **Cleaning:** empty spray bottles, sponges, scrubbers, trash bags, laundry packaging.
- **Takeout and delivery:** containers, cutlery, sauce packets, bags, drink cups and lids.
- **Other:** anything else. Write down what it was.

> **Tip:** Start when you wake up, not at midnight. Your day ends when you go to bed.

Your One-Day Tally

Date: _____ Who is counted: _____

Make one mark per item, in groups of five (||||/).

CATEGORY	TALLY MARKS	TOTAL	WHAT WAS IT?
Food packaging			
Produce bags			
Paper towels and wipes			
Coffee and tea			
Bathroom			
Cleaning			
Takeout and delivery			
Other			
Day total			

Was today a normal day? If not, what was different?

Anything that surprised you?

Read Your Day

Do this the same evening, while you still remember what the marks were.

Your two biggest rows

Write the two categories with the most marks.

RANK	CATEGORY	MARKS	THE ITEM THAT REPEATED MOST
1			
2			

Three questions about the top row

Does this item come back every day, or was today unusual?

Is it one item repeating (the same tea bag, five times), or many different items?

Do you already own something that could take its place? A cloth, a jar, a container, a bag?

> **What to look for:** One item that repeats is the easiest thing to change. Many different items in one row usually point to a shopping habit, and that takes a full week of counting to see clearly.

A row with nothing in it

An empty row is also a result. If "Takeout and delivery" has no marks because today was not a takeout day, you have learned what one day cannot show you. Make a note of it.

One Thing to Try This Week

Pick one item from your top row. Not a category. One item.

The item:

Use what you have first

The lowest-waste product is the one already in your home. Before you buy anything, look for something you own that does the same job. Old towels cut into cloths. A jar with a lid. A mug you carry with you. A container you take to the shop.

What I already own that could do this job:

A seven-day trial

Try the change for seven days. Keep the old item in the house, so that a hard day does not end the trial.

The day I start: _____

Where I will keep the replacement, so that it is easier to reach than the old item:

What I will do when I forget:

- ☐ Day 1
- ☐ Day 2
- ☐ Day 3
- ☐ Day 4
- ☐ Day 5

- [ ] Day 6
- [ ] Day 7

> **Skip buying if:** you have not finished the seven days, or the thing you own already works. A reusable product pays off only when you use it many times. Buying it and leaving it in a drawer adds waste.

After seven days

Did the change hold? What got in the way?

What a Full Week Adds

One day gave you a first look. It cannot give you a number you can plan with. A full week can, because a week contains your shopping day, your takeout night and your cleaning day.

The Waste Audit Workbook is the full version of this method. It has:

- Seven daily tally sheets and a weekly summary.
- A worksheet that turns the week into a yearly count, with a correction for items you buy rarely.
- A ranking page that scores each candidate swap by how often the item repeats and how easy the change is.
- A flag for swaps that need many uses before they are worth buying.
- A 90-day re-audit page, so you can see whether the change held.

It is a printable PDF and costs $7. If you ask within 30 days, you get your money back.

Find it at link-flame.vivancedata.com/products.

You do not need it to keep going. You can repeat this one-day sheet on six more days and add the rows up yourself. The workbook saves you the arithmetic and adds the ranking.

Most people begin with one swap, not twenty. Make yours the one your own count pointed to.

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This guide offers general information about reducing household waste. Local recycling and composting rules vary; check with your municipality.